He put me in touch with Nick Matthew, the former world number one squash player, calculating that we were similar characters. I had played the game a lot as a youngster and understood the nature of Nick's success. Like myself, he got the most from his natural ability. He worked tremendously hard and ground down the opposition. He had an innate durability to work through unpromising situations and daunting deficits.

I became increasingly self-aware. I was suited to a team environment, since I was one of those characters who was rock solid 99 per cent of the time. I had learned to develop a game face after watching Michael Vaughan and Andrew Strauss; you could never tell, at first glance, whether they had made a duck or a century.

I realized that was so important. The last thing a team needs is for a bloke at the top of the order to be too up or down. There are a lot of times when the odds are against you, and you can't give away too much about private thought processes. I think such self-containment comes from my mum. My dad is very sociable but self-effacing; he once went an entire tour of Sri Lanka, sharing rooms in a travel group, without telling any of his companions that I was his son.

My parents gave me the space as a boy to become my own man. Choir school taught me about an individual's responsibility to the group. Boarding schools were hierarchical, but I never experienced the bullying that characterized earlier generations. That's not to say it didn't exist, but sport was my passport, spiritually and socially.

As a leader of men, I tried to set the example of being low maintenance. I rarely saw the physio, unless I had an obvious problem. I identified most closely with the bowlers, who were prepared to act selflessly and put the hard yards in – I barely had a massage, because I believed they needed the release more than me.

Captaincy entailed dealing with emotion, which is so often a by-product of stress. It also involved an investment of faith. In the most pressurized moments, basic themes, such as trust, unity and generosity of spirit, came to the fore. They won us a pivotal Ashes Test match, at Trent Bridge in 2013.

Australia began the fifth day needing 137 runs to win, with four wickets remaining. What transpired also involved the application of a combination of learned skills, raw cunning, natural talent and nerveless defiance. It was tense, relentless and draining. My role initially involved the learned skill, slip catching.